

MEETING MINUTES

Medford School Committee of the Whole Meeting

Budget FY24

Monday April 03, 2023

4:30pm - 6pm

The meeting was held in the Howard Alden Memorial Chambers, Medford City Hall as well as remotely via Zoom and viewed through Medford Community Media on Comcast Channel 15 and Verizon Channel 45 starting at 4:30pm.

Roll Call: 6/0

Absent: Member Mea Mustone

Superintendent, Dr. Marice Edouard-Vincent made a 2nd budget presentation of the Fiscal Year 2024 Medford Public Schools Operating Budget to the Medford School Committee for FY24 funding requests, focusing on Strategic Priorities concerning equitable supports for our most vulnerable students.

Dr. Cushing managed the screen share of the presentation.

Questions from the Committee:

Member Ruseau questions the reduction of the engagement specialist - have we not hired enough or getting rid some. Assumes we are not suddenly paying them less.

Superintendent, Dr. Marice Edouard-Vincent confirms we currently do not have the full cadre of 5. Based on what we were seeing with the unanticipated costs, we were looking at all the different fixed increases. Expenses and personnel salaries have gone up. Speaks to Slides 4 and 5 where the the base is getting bigger and both numbers are going up and salaries.

Member Ruseau feels the presentation is a presentation of our approved budget allocation vs. our budget request. Speaks to the past two years budget requests specifying what we wanted and needed to separate the district, and then we figured out how to squeeze all that down into the number we got from the city. Feels we are squeezing ahead of time, which means that when we go and ask the City Council ... speaks then to the engagement specialist and queries if 5 is even enough. The right number is 7 but if the right number to support our children is 7, then we should be putting 7 down here, so that when we ask the City Council, whatever the number is, that we say we need 77 million dollars and we get a smaller number in the Mayor's budget, that's the way it's supposed to work. Going in already we're chopping and being told we don't need 5 engagement specialists, and the kids are fine and the specific role for them is enough, then he will believe you. You've just described this as a way to save money and it seems like that the step in our last slide that's Steps 1, 2, 3, 4, 5 - that's step 6, and step 7 except we're only in step 2. He sees the reading specialist went up, but that is not a money saving situation. The slide is a mixture of attempts to save money however he doesn't know what the right number is and to be cutting at the early phase seems backward.

Member Ruseau presents a second question regarding the budgetary priorities for expanded school day staff ..

Superintendent, Dr. Marice Edouard-Vincent confirms this is the same as after-school and includes surround care workers.

Member Ruseau is surprised by that number and notes we have not budgeted anything for after school

other than the Director and the rest is covered in the revolving account. This seems to suggest we are going to use our allocation we get from the city and spend some of that on after-school and seeks confirmation.

Superintendent, Dr. Marice Edouard-Vincent confirms we are using the revolving accounts as well and to the extent possible to help provide support. After school programming is a key priority and an area where we're trying to beef up staff to support the after school program. We have attempted to recruit additional staff to support our programming and with the creation of this new position, we would hope to have built-in staff that would be working during the instructional day and then helping to provide cover with the after school programming. They would essentially be part of surround care and instead of a traditional school day, hours would be adjusted to meet an after school need. It's a creative measure and something we've talked about before.

Member Ruseau does not have a problem with what the Superintendent described. He wants to be careful and make sure we don't get into any kind of slippery situation around the operating budget and what it covers (K-12) and the school day. If we want to start pulling other stuff in, then that expands our scope of what the budget is supposed to cover.

Member Graham asks what the total ESSER grant is for all three combined.

Superintendent, Dr. Marice Edouard-Vincent does not have the total for all three but will get that information. Going into FY24, we have 3 million left.

Member Graham would like to see a picture that shows all the money that we have (7.2 or 6.7 - is unclear on the figure), what we spent in FY22, FY23 and what we plan to spend in FY24 and how did we get to the place where there's 3 million dollars left in FY24. If she counts up what's on the FY23 page, if there was a total on the page, it would be 2.7. If there was a total on the FY24 number, it would be 1.5 based on what she tried to calculate. She is trying to understand how the money has been spent over time and one of the things from last year was paying for things that were clearly operating budget with ESSER. She would like to know where that fits into how we're taking down our ESSER funds because we should spend all of it. More importantly, if we have to make plans for that money to come back into the operating budget, we need to know they are not one time items - that are recurring. She echoes Member Ruseau's comments about wanting to make sure our initial budget request is actually the request that outlines what we need to promote teaching and learning in our district. She would like to see a clear picture of ESSER and we should proactively demonstrate to the community that we are being fiscally responsible.

Superintendent, Dr. Marice Edouard-Vincent confirms we have a total - ESSER funding was 8.35 million.

Member Graham states there is therefore a 1.5 million not earmarked out of the 3 (million) remaining.

Mayor Lungo-Koehn addresses Superintendent for clarity - this is the last year we can use it but that it bleeds into the first quarter of Fiscal Year 25, so not sure how much the district plans on holding ESSER because we will need it for a portion of it, especially when we have so many positions and there is going to be a portion to be held for Fiscal Year 25. This is how it's being negotiated on the city side.

Member Graham asks further: if there is still 1.5 million dollars, if a portion of this needs to be held for FY25, we need to know what that is now, so we can make sure there are funds to cover costs. Speaks to the page with the asterisk that reflects preliminary information and is subject to change after the results of the budget surveys and asks for clarification - does this list not integrate what we all put in our budget?

Superintendent, Dr. Marice Edouard-Vincent confirms it does not. That will be a more developed and categorized list.

Member McLaughlin would like to give a broad understanding to the community as to what has happened in the past 3 years - at the next meeting. Speaks to Member Graham's point of spending down and the use of ESSER funds that will stop and we may be faced with a decision as to what to do. Thinks it would be helpful to have a primer intro into the school committee budget process - maybe for the next meeting, to help those watching who don't really understand the process, in particular with regard to ESSER funding. Also wants to ask about the stages in the back, the last page for the budget process and tentative timeline in that explanation. Asks what the expectation would be for the April 3rd, 10th and May 1 meeting. For Example - the April 3rd meeting we are going to go over a broad introduction to give an outline of what's been spent, how it's been spent and what we think issues may be moving forward to a broader picture. What people can expect for the 10th and the 1st. Asks if we need to have a public meeting specifically ...

Superintendent, Dr. Marice Edouard-Vincent confirms that based on how the Budget COW's go, the committee chooses to go further or if you feel we get to a good point, this public meeting would take place either the late May or early June meeting would be the public hearing - which needs to be posted 2 weeks in advance.

Member McLaughlin: can we include this in the timeline?

Superintendent, Dr. Marice Edouard-Vincent confirms in the affirmative.

Member McLaughlin comments on the pie chart on page 1. Asks for an explanation for the FY23 budget numbers - the approximations for student services at the 5.25%

Superintendent, Dr. Marice Edouard-Vincent confirms that is inclusive of athletics - it's actually a more global term - it's inclusive of any services related to students - including athletics and that approximately 5%. It is separate from the special education which is the 25%. She can ask for the breakdown of the 5% and will be able to provide a full breakout for that listing for next week's presentation as well.

Member McLaughlin: last question is with regard to the summer budgetary priorities; knows the summer programming is grant dependant - wants to know that central administration is working/planning inclusivity and equity around the programming for the summer, so that we're thinking about all of the student population, especially the most vulnerable affected by the pandemic. States this is more of a statement than a question.

Member Ruseau states he signed the warrants but it occurred to him he didn't sign a warrant for water. Questions if the municipality provides it for free? Comments "wonderful and nice that he has one bill. His other question was with regard to the slide regarding "Areas of Concern". He appreciates the use of color there because some of the items cause some alarm. He feels it is too soon to talk about downsizing however, in the Advocate for Investment - questions who is advocating and with whom? Believe part of the committee's job is to advocate for investment and the communities are everybody's responsibility. She is wondering what is meant by that in this context. Is it speaking with the Mayor - he does not see the administration spending time talking with State legislators - so doesn't know what that means.

Superintendent, Dr. Marice Edouard-Vincent shares that through this process, and looking at what our needs are, she is aware that she presented some of the big surprises that we weren't expecting changes or unanticipated costs for this year - we really do want to advocate for investment in the school system, looking at the needs of the district, looking at the needs of all of our students and planning for unexpected contingencies that happen within the district. It was there to show that these are the areas that we're going to try to continue to represent for the district.

Member Hays: in looking at the FY23 ESSER estimate budget - did we hire additional adjustment counselors with ESSER (funds). She does not see them on her - perhaps she is thinking of the behavioral specialist.

Superintendent, Dr. Marice Edouard-Vincent confirms she does see a behavioral specialist listed. She cannot say if their title was an adjustment counselor but can follow up to find out.

Mayor Lungo-Koehn - recognizes Ms. Bowen is shaking her head, affirming it was a behaviorist specialist.

Member Graham - refers to the slide that talks about fixed cost increases - and questions the second bullet that talks about contractual increases. In one place she saw 1 million dollars and here she sees 3.3 million dollars. Is the increase over FY23 1 million dollars or 3.3 million dollars.

Superintendent, Dr. Marice Edouard-Vincent seeks confirmation that for FY23 - if the question being asked is on special education increase - which is 1 million dollars - and then the contractual increases amounting to 3.3 million dollars?

Member Graham is looking for clarification on the numbers and is trying to understand the personnel increase. Special Education will go up a million dollars and vendors will go up 100 thousand dollars - she is trying to understand the personnel numbers?

Member McLaughlin responds

Superintendent, Dr. Marice Edouard-Vincent responds for FY24 we would need in order to work with all the changes and adjustments, it would need to be in that 3.3 million (confirmed) for contractual increases for all.

Member Graham states that 3.3 million is 4.7% increase over the 68,994. If the contractual increase is just 2.5%, how does the increase ...

Mayor Lungo-Koehn interject - 2.5% this year is 2.9

Member Graham asks what the real add is over 68,994 included an increase -

Superintendent, Dr. Marice Edouard-Vincent responds 4%. 2.5% is the Cola amount and that's not including steps and lanes as well as all the unions, in addition to the MTA. Even though it is a 2.5% increase, it ends up feeling like it's closer to a 4% increase.

Member Graham states that 3.3 is the real number

Superintendent, Dr. Marice Edouard-Vincent agrees and confirms she will have the numbers checked for the April 10th meeting presentation.

Mayor Lungo-Koehn her question is with regard to the cleaning contract - and would like to be clear - it seems we have the custodians doing the work in all of our schools and there are only one or 2 schools that use this cleaning contract.

Superintendent, Dr. Marice Edouard-Vincent confirms the McGlynn and the High school contracts have the most community usage. Events happening - those are the two complexes that are used almost 24/7. Those are the two buildings that have the most usage and contract cleaners come in on the second shift due to the volume of activities that take place. The McGlynn complex is essentially two schools in one, so you're talking about 1000 students and the high school has 1300 students. It gets the most usage and rentals.

Mayor Lungo-Koehn asks if there are the same amount of custodians in each school.

Superintendent, Dr. Marice Edouard-Vincent confirms yes - the same amount of custodians in each school during the day shifts but she will get a specific number. Believes there are more custodians assigned to the high school due to the size.

Mayor Lungo-Koehn asks for an update for the next week or the week after, based on the percentage increase, will we be increasing any user fees for outside agencies that use our school to account for some of this increase in cleaning costs and a breakdown of what user fees we're bringing in now so we know what's being covered.

Member Graham makes a suggestion that we separate the revolving accounts because of that (cleaning costs/user fees??) goes into revolving accounts and she thinks to the point of after school - none of that belongs in the conversation about 68,996 body, body blah (?) because it muddies the water about what's in there and what isn't. If we can get this work done by May 15, we will have some breathing room and we can have the conversation around revolving accounts which we've wanted to have for a long time and never been able to have due to the crunch on the budget. To your point (?) If we're going to incur additional costs, the user fees need to go up if we're letting people use the buildings.

Member McLaughlin regarding the budget concerns - is the 14% increase in audit district tuition because the schools have increased their tuition or because we have an increase in the number of students going out of district or both.

Mayor Lungo-Koehn responds that Governor Baker signed that before he left.

Ms. Bowen speaks - confirms that was not an increase in the number of students and that was an increase based on the state. What they're doing is they want to raise their cost of living and also offer bonuses to keep staff members on board - that was the increase across the board for all other district placements, except for the collaboratives. She mentions she will do a presentation next meeting (April 10, 2023) regarding out of district programming and our current numbers and placements.

Member Kretz - looking at the slide FY Budgetary priorities draft, where there is a need and the needs are listed out, do the figures tie back to the slide above .. questions the need for theater teachers, how much money would we need to fill those positions. Questions if we are going to see estimates at some point?

Superintendent, Dr. Marice Edouard-Vincent confirms no official numbers have been provided or been broken out. Talks about restorative justice, high school scheduling, and the broader summer offerings that were offered last summer, we would like to continue to offer during the summer for our community.

Member Kretz wonders if, in the future, will the various departments' priority categories be identified.

Superintendent, Dr. Marice Edouard-Vincent confirms this does not include the priorities listed in the budget surveys.

MEETING ADJOURNS: 5:43pm

Motion to adjourn by Member Graham; seconded by Member Kretz

Motion passes 6/0